



▲ BRILLIANT WHITE SILICA SANDS OF WHITEHAVEN BEACH

El Nido

Location Northern Palawan Island, Philippines

Spanish for “the nest,” El Nido is the gateway to the famous Bacuit Archipelago. El Nido comprises the northern tip of Palawan Island as well as 45 islands and islets. Erosion of thick layers of limestone has produced a spectacular landscape of coastal karst, with cliffs towering vertically from the sea, combined with caves, white sand beaches, and coral reefs. The Secret Lagoon on Miniloc Island is a sea-filled cavern that can only be accessed via a narrow entrance. Experienced divers access a submarine tunnel beneath Dilumacad Island through an entrance that is 39 ft (12 m) below the water surface. The fauna of the offshore reefs include pipefish, pufferfish, scorpionfish, lionfish, and many other beautiful creatures.

Other coasts, islands, and reefs in Asia

- **Andaman Sea Reefs** » p.253
- **Dragon Hole** » p.251
- **Ha Long Bay** » p.250-51
- **The Krabi Coastline** » p.252-53
- **The Maldives** » p.315
- **Nusa Tenggara** » p.253
- **Shiraho Reef** » p.251

Australia and New Zealand

Horizontal Falls

Location Talbot Bay, Buccaneer Archipelago, western Australia

These tidal waterfalls are produced as ocean water pours through narrow gorges cutting through the two parallel rock barriers of

the McLarty Ranges. On a rising tide, water builds up on one side of the barriers more quickly than it can push through the gorges. The resultant difference in water level reaches 16 ft (5 m) and produces the waterfall.

Whitehaven Beach

Location Whitsunday Island, Queensland, Australia

The origin of Whitehaven’s 4 miles (7 km) of fine, bright white sand has long been debated. Whitsunday Island is part of an ancient volcanic caldera, but its sand—which is 98 percent quartz—could not have come from the island’s igneous rhyolite and dacite rocks. In fact, it is derived from eroded granite on the Queensland mainland and was deposited by ancient longshore drift. This conveyor belt of coastal movement stopped at least 6,500 years ago, but the sand remains.

Ninety Mile Beach

Location West coast of Aupouri Peninsula, North Island, New Zealand

Despite its name, this strip of sand, which faces the Tasman Sea, actually stretches 55 miles (88 km) between the rocky headlands of Scott Point and Ahipara. Even more remarkable are the sand dunes—probably the largest dunes in the Southern Hemisphere and a renowned sandboarding site—that lie behind the beach. The dunes increase in height from south to north, culminating in summits more than 460 ft (140 m) high.

Other coasts, islands, and reefs in Australia and New Zealand

- **The Great Barrier Reef** » pp.284-87
- **Moeraki Beach** » p.290
- **New Zealand Fjords** » p.291
- **Shark Bay** » pp.288-89
- **The Twelve Apostles** » p.290